

Look, watch, hear, and listen

Teaching guide

Describe attention and perception.

Understand the distinction

Look at directs visual attention toward something. Watch usually involves attention over time, often to something changing or moving. Hear describes receiving sound; listen emphasizes paying attention to it.

Use to before the object of listen: listen to music. Hear does not need to before its object. The attention distinction is useful but not absolute: hear a speaker can also mean attend a talk. Learn familiar activity phrases such as watch television and look at a photo.

Compare the patterns

DIRECT ATTENTION

Look at this photo.

Turn your attention to it.

OVER TIME

We watched the match.

Follow an event as it develops.

SOUND

I heard music and stopped to listen to it.

The sound was perceived, then attended to.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: Please listen ___ the announcement.

A. at

B. to

C. for to

2. Choose the verb for viewing the game as it happened: We ___ the game.

A. watched

B. listened

C. looked

3. Choose the correction: I heard to a loud noise.

A. I listened a loud noise.

B. I heard at a loud noise.

C. I heard a loud noise.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You first noticed a voice, then paid attention to an announcement. Which pair fits?

- A. I heard a voice outside. I listened the announcement.
- B. I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.
- C. I heard to a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. to

Listen takes to before the object.

A: Listen takes to before the thing you intentionally attend to.

C: Use listen to the announcement without for.

2. A. watched

Watch is natural for following a game.

B: Listen would need to and would describe attending to sound rather than watching.

C: With the game as the direct object, watch fits. Look would need at.

3. C. I heard a loud noise.

Hear takes the object directly.

A: Listen needs to; hear takes its object directly.

B: Hear takes a loud noise directly, without at.

4. B. I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

Heard describes noticing sound; listened to describes deliberate attention.

A: Listen needs to before the object.

C: Hear takes its object directly, without to.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-39.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

You first noticed a voice, then paid attention to an announcement. Which pair fits?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.